

The STEPS program will address the challenges associated with our complex and inefficient cargo import processes and systems.

Our aim is to:

- simplify biosecurity import processes and make it easier to comply
- modernise and increase digitisation of our services
- increase data sharing.

Our approach will benefit both industry and government, while supporting more effective biosecurity management.

STEPS is a \$145 million, 3-year program of work. It will run from 2023-2026.

Benefits of the program

Benefits to industry will include:

- Reduced commercial holding costs due to greater efficiencies
- more cargo able to be managed under approved arrangements
- better visibility of cargo that is being managed by us, so industry can make cost effective decisions about imported cargo
- improved data on where import requirements haven't been met, so industry can undertake better assurance oversight
- more self-service options to reduce on the need to contact us for routine matters
- support to submit accurate biosecurity documentation and accelerate the clearance process at the border.

How we will deliver

STEPS will build on previous investments made through the Biosecurity Integrated Information System (BIIS).

We will:

- enhance existing platforms
- streamline the applications involved in cargo and container management
- explore options to expand self-service capabilities
- share relevant and useful data to enable industry to better control their own workflows.

STEPS is working directly with industry to understand how you want to work with us. Our focus is to streamline the number of interaction points and equip you to make it easier to manage the import process.

Your insights are important to us. If you have any questions, or would like to be involved in STEPS consultation email STEPS@aff.gov.au

What we have delivered

In 2024, we've delivered products to increase self-service options and share key data to industry.

Approved Arrangements Management Product (AAMP)

AAMP enables Biosecurity Industry Participants (BIPs) who operate Approved Arrangements (AAs) to view and update their AA details via self-service. This means you won't have to contact us.

AAMP was progressively rolled out from June to August 2024 to all BIPs in relation to 85 classes of AA.

External Verification of eCertificates (EVE)

EVE allows accredited brokers to view a secure eCert (phytosanitary certificate) as they assess commodities under an approved arrangement.

This is a first step towards providing access to digital certificates in a self-service format.

EVE was released at the end of June 2024. New Zealand is the first country included in EVE. Digital certificates from new countries will then be added as soon as they come online.

Biosecurity industry reporting

Industry reporting provides approved arrangement class 19 biosecurity industry participants and accredited persons with visibility of their in-progress entries referred to the department. The reports allow users to search for a specific entry to find details on:

- cargo status
- records of service (fees)
- approved arrangement class 19.2 usage and uptake.

Accredited persons can access the industry reporting on the [Biosecurity Portal](#).

The cargo status reporting was released in November 2024. The record of service (fees) reporting was released in May 2025. The approved arrangement class 19.2 usage and uptake reporting was released in July 2025.

Additional reports will be developed over time to provide greater self-service capability.

Upgrades to the Cargo Online Lodgement System (COLS)

The existing Cargo Online Lodgement System (COLS) will become the single channel for document lodgement, removing the need for assessors to use manual processes that include mailboxes and emails for some imports. This will support the department's ability to meet its Service Level Agreements.

In November 2024, as a direct result of industry engagement and feedback, the STEPS team successfully delivered an enhancement to increase the upload file size limit from 10MB to 20MB. This delivers on commitments to improve the document lodgement process for industry. Further upgrades are planned.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/import/online-services/steps-program>